8 Religion, morality, and politics

It is commonly believed that morality is importantly and fundamentally connected with the existence of God. The remark, famously (if not quite accurately) attributed to Dostoyevsky, that "without God, all is (morally) permissible," captures a view shared by many devout religious believers and many atheists as well. Indeed, such a view reflects the majority opinion within Western philosophy throughout most of its history.

The belief in an intrinsic connection between morality and the existence of God explains, among other things, the historical proliferation of arguments for theism based on various types of moral facts. Aristotle, St. Thomas Aquinas, Leibniz, Kant, and many others believed and argued that there is something about morality that simply makes no sense unless there is a God. Yet, despite its widespread appeal, the belief in such a connection is not at all widely endorsed by contemporary moral philosophers. Most contemporary moral philosophers are quite content with the idea that morality can be explained entirely in naturalistic terms. As a result, much less attention has been paid to the connections between religion and morality in philosophy over the last hundred years.

There is more than one reason for this shift. The most important of these is that many moral philosophers have become increasingly doubtful that morals belong in the domain of objective fact. As William Lycan has observed, "Moral facts are right up there ... in the ranks of items uncordially despised by most contemporary philosophers."[1] If moral claims derive their truth and authority merely from human preferences or desires then we can explain everything that needs to be explained about morality simply by appealing to facts about human minds, their contents, or their

[1] William Lycan, *Judgement and Justification* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1988), p. 198, quoted in Charles Taliaferro, *Contemporary Philosophy of Religion* (Malden, MA: Blackwell Publishers, 1998), p. 193.

activities; as a result, appeals to God or to other supernatural entities would be rendered superfluous. It is thus fitting to begin this chapter by assessing the reasons that have been offered for thinking that morality is not objective.

Ethical objectivism and ethical subjectivism

Philosophers commonly draw a distinction between objective and subjective claims. Objective claims are claims like *George Washington was the first president of the United States*, $1 + 1 = 2$, and *the Earth has four moons*. The first two of those claims are objectively true, while the third is objectively false. Objective claims are characterized by two distinguishing marks:

(i) They are not mere expressions of taste, desire, or attitude.
(ii) They have absolute truth values – that is, they aren't merely "true for so-and-so" or "true in this or that culture" (whatever exactly those "true for" expressions might mean).

Subjective claims on the other hand lack these features. So, for example, to say that vanilla is better than chocolate, that soccer is boring, or that it is bad to belch out loud after a good meal is *not* to say something that is straightforwardly true or false. Rather, it is to say something that is, we might say, "true for you" but maybe not true for someone else. What does it mean to say that a sentence is true for you? Plausibly, all it means is that the sentence in question merely expresses your attitudes or preferences rather than making an assertion about some fact in the world. (Note, in this connection, that a sentence *about* your attitudes, preferences, or tastes – e.g. a sentence like "Sally prefers chocolate" – *would* be an objective claim, since it would assert an alleged fact about the world and would, therefore, have a truth value. Thus, the difference between objective and subjective facts isn't that the latter *depend* on human attitudes and preferences, as some are inclined to say. For, after all, the truth of "Sally prefers chocolate" is wholly dependent on human preferences – namely, Sally's. Rather, the difference is that subjective claims do nothing more, really, than *express* human attitudes or preferences.)

The distinction between objective and subjective claims can be applied in the ethical domain as well to provide us with two broad views concerning morality. Let's call these views *moral objectivism* and *moral subjectivism*.

Discerning whether or not there is any important philosophical connection between religion and morality will first require that we come to some conclusion on the question of whether or not moral objectivism or moral subjectivism is more plausible. If subjectivisim is more plausible, there will be little or no connection. Moral claims will be dependent for their truth on the beliefs, desires, and decisions of human beings and will amount to nothing more than a form of human convention. If objectivism is true, however, a number of important philosophical puzzles arise. For example, if moral claims are objective, then there must be some mind-independent facts which make these moral claims true. But what sorts of facts might these be? On first inspection, ordinary non-moral facts seem incapable of grounding the truth of these objective moral claims and this might incline us to think that supernatural facts will have to be called in to fill the role.

Of course, such questions are out of place if there are good reasons to think that moral claims are, in the end, subjective. What reasons are there to favor such a view? In what follows we discuss two arguments for subjectivism.[2]

Two arguments for subjectivism

The most common argument for moral subjectivism starts by pointing out the vast diversity of moral beliefs across times and cultures. It is no surprise to learn that different cultures accept widely divergent moral beliefs. Some cultures affirm the moral acceptability of slavery, infanticide, theft, genital mutilation, ritual rape, and so on (while others disagree). Likewise, some cultures affirm the moral goodness of truth-telling, humility, equal rights for all persons, beneficence, and so on (while others disagree). Given this diversity of moral belief it seems hard to believe that moral claims are objective, such that for each of them there is a *single right answer* when it comes to questions about their truth or falsity. As a result, moral subjectivism is true.

A second argument against moral objectivism arises out of an *epistemological* concern. Moral facts seem quite unlike the sorts of non-moral facts with which we are acquainted. Most of what we know we seem to know

[2] The following arguments are derived from J. L. Mackie, *Ethics: Inventing Right and Wrong*.

either by way of some sort of experience (usually sensory experience, but maybe religious experience as well) or by analyzing our concepts. It is easy to see how we can come into contact with the sorts of facts investigated by science, and it is likewise easy to see how we could come into contact with facts about how our concepts are related to one another. But how could we possibly come into contact with *moral* facts? How could we possibly *discover*, say, that it is wrong to own slaves or good to help the poor? We don't go digging in the dirt to discover these truths; and we can't discover them simply by analyzing the meanings of the terms we use. Thus, the sorts of facts with which morality seems to deal are *weird* – so weird, in fact, that it is hard for many philosophers to believe that they exist.

Assessing the arguments for subjectivism

The first and most common argument is also the least compelling of the two. The mere fact of moral disagreement comes nowhere close, on its own, to settling the question of whether moral claims are objective or subjective. To see why, we have only to note that there has been widespread disagreement about all sorts of obviously objective claims. Does the earth stand still or orbit the sun? People disagreed – even bitterly. But there is only one right answer. What this shows is that even though in some cases disagreement occurs because the claim at question is subjective, in other cases it occurs because someone is just wrong.

Likewise, the question of whether moral claims are subjective is not settled by the further fact that moral disagreement is very hard to resolve. Students often note that the difference between moral claims and, say, the claim that the earth orbits the sun is that there is no *proof* (scientific or otherwise) for the former sort of claim, but there is for the latter. There is no *publicly available evidence* to which we can point to resolve the disagreement. But the same is true of a wide variety of clearly objective claims as well. What did Julius Caesar have for breakfast on the day of his death? What was the most often-read book in the famed Library of Alexandria? No one will ever know; and if people were to take views on these questions, there would be no evidence on the basis of which we could ultimately resolve the disagreement. But that fact goes no distance whatsoever toward showing that these claims are subjective. In fact, the idea that they are merely subjective is flatly absurd.

How do we know, then, whether a claim is objective or subjective? We have to consider it in light of the two distinguishing marks identified above. Is it reasonable to think that it is an expression of individual preferences or attitudes? Is it plausible to think of it as the sort of claim that is neither absolutely true nor absolutely false, but merely "true for so-and-so" at any given time? If the answer to both questions is yes, then we have reason to think that the claim is subjective. Knowing, for example, that the claim in question is one for which we could have no publicly available evidence, or about which people might interminably disagree, might give us some insight into these questions; but it hardly settles them.

Consider, then, how all of this might work with respect to a particular moral claim, such as "Genocide is immoral." Is this claim an expression of individual preferences or attitudes? Is it merely true for us, but not for others? It seems highly plausible that the answer to both questions is no. To see why, consider what a "yes" answer would mean. If we were to answer yes to the first question, we would be committed to thinking that if an individual or group of individuals *valued* genocide, then it would for that very reason *be moral*. Surely this is wrong-headed. Genocide is wrong for everyone, not just for us and people who share our preferences and attitudes. If anyone thinks genocide is morally commendable (or takes genocide to be desirable) they are not simply different from us, they are drastically and frighteningly morally mistaken (or corrupt, or both). For the same reason, a "yes" answer to the second question is equally unacceptable. If "genocide is immoral" can be true for some people and false for others, then we are committed to the claim that some people *rightly* see genocide as perfectly morally permissible (perhaps even morally *commendable*). Again, such a position is surely incredible. Any theory on the nature of morality which leads us to conclude that genocide (or slavery, or human sacrifice, or ritual rape) might be morally permissible or commendable should, for that very reason, be rejected. Indeed, if such a consequence were not a sufficient reason to reject a theory of morality, it would be hard to know what would be.

The second argument for the conclusion that moral claims are subjective is also problematic. It turns on the idea that moral facts are unique – very different from the sorts of non-moral facts with which we are most familiar. Since it is hard to see how we could have access to such facts, moral facts are declared strange and, on that basis, we are advised to disbelieve in them.

But this way of reasoning simply ignores a wide range of facts that seem no less "strange" than moral facts but which few people are willing to dismiss simply on the basis of their strangeness.

Moral claims are a species of *normative* claim. That is, they express norms – they tell us what we *ought* to do. But there are other kinds of normative claim as well. For example, when we talk about what it is to be rational, we talk, among other things, about what sorts of beliefs are justified or unjustified, warranted or unwarranted; and in so doing, we are talking about what beliefs we think *ought* to be held or rejected in light of certain kinds of evidence. When we are injured – with a torn muscle, or a detached retina, say – we naturally speak as if the relevant part of our body is not functioning as it *ought* to function. Disease is sometimes thought of in terms of malfunction: when we are ill, our bodies are not as they ought to be. None of the "oughts" here are moral; but they are normative nonetheless. But whatever problems arise for grounding our knowledge of normative moral claims will equally arise for grounding our knowledge of these other normative claims. If moral claims are strange, then so are their epistemological or physiological counterparts. Yet, relatively few of us will be willing to jettison the idea that there are norms of rationality or physiological norms on account of their strangeness. Thus, it is hard to see why we should think that moral claims have a *special* sort of strangeness that makes them, more than these other sorts of claims, candidates for rejection.

The two central questions

Our short discussion of objectivism and subjectivism does not consider the full complexity of the arguments for and against each view, but it does indicate that it is by no means clear that ethical subjectivism is the best or only option. If we embrace ethical objectivism, two questions immediately arise, and these two questions are arguably the central problems for ethical objectivism. These questions will occupy our remaining discussion of the connection between religion and morality.

The first question is: what explains the truth of moral claims? If moral objectivism is true, then there are moral facts (like *its being wrong to torture small children for fun*) and moral properties (like goodness, wrongness, and so on). But where do these facts come from? What explains why one moral property rather than another is exemplified by an act or circumstance? Are

these just brute features of the universe, or are they brought about by something? Moral objectivists owe us some answers here.

The second question is: even if moral claims are objectively true, why should we care about them? Those who are new to philosophy or to moral theory often find this question baffling. Isn't there something about morality, they wonder, which makes it automatically important to us? When someone points out the fact that some action you are considering is immoral, and you acknowledge that she is right, doesn't this alone give you a good reason not to do it? We all seem to think that the answer is yes. There is something quite absurd about saying, "I realize that it is entirely immoral to do X; but, really, I have no reason not to do it." And yet, this fact itself is puzzling. Why does morality have this seemingly intrinsically motivating character? Why does it seem not to be a rational option for you to declare that you simply don't care about morality?

To grasp fully what is at stake here it is important that we get clear about what ethical claims are and about what distinguishes them from other sorts of claims. What makes something an ethical claim? Beyond being objective (an assumption for the purposes of this discussion), ethical claims have at least three distinguishing features: (i) they are action guiding; (ii) they apply universally; and (iii) they render us worthy of moral blame when we violate them and moral praise when we follow them. Others might be identified as well, but these three will suffice for present purposes.

What does it mean to say that moral claims are universal? One thing it means is that they prescribe actions (or states of character) as good or bad for us regardless of our interests in those actions or states. Not all action-guiding claims are like this. If you want to win the 5km race next year, you should train a few times each week. But the "should" in that sentence is action guiding only on the supposition that you want to win the race. If you don't care about running or winning the race, it is not true that you should train a few times a week. The "should" we find in moral claims is different. If you admit a certain moral claim to be true, "You should not steal" for example, you can't escape the action-guiding force of the claim by saying that you don't really care about being moral. Unlike other sorts of action-guiding claims whose force is only *conditional* or *hypothetical*, moral claims have a force that is universal or, in the language of moral philosophers, *categorical*.

In addition, ethical claims, unlike other action-guiding claims, are action guiding in such a way that once we understand or appreciate their moral

character, we take ourselves to have not only *a* reason to do them, but *sufficient reason* to do them. When you consider performing an action, there are all sorts of reasons for and against it that might weigh in the balance. If an action will advance your career, enrich your fortune, make your friends and family members happy, and so on, then there is some reason for you to do it. But these reasons can be overridden by other reasons that are outweighing. When we make practical decisions we are continually forced to weigh these competing reasons against one another. Sally wants to advance the happiness of one of her children by paying for her to have very expensive bagpipe lessons. But she also wants to send the child to college. And if these goals come into conflict, one will have to take priority. If the only way to provide bagpipe lessons is to give up saving for college, Sally might think that it is just tough luck for bagpiping. She might regard saving for college as more important. Thus, for her, one set of reasons – those that favor college – are overriding. And so, given her value structure and her circumstances, she *ought* to forgo the bagpipe lessons in favor of saving for college.

For Sally, the reasons she has for saving for her child's education override her reasons for wanting to provide bagpipe lessons. But the college-related reasons could be overridden as well. Thus, it might turn out that, given her value structure, if her circumstances were to change in some way, then she ought *not* to save for college. In the case of morality, however, *nothing* overrides. That is part of what is unique about morality. When moral reasons oblige us to do a certain action, or to refrain from a certain action, other non-moral reasons must take a back seat. Moral reasons are in this way *intrinsically overriding*. Thus, for example, even though Sally might be willing to sacrifice a lot to send her child to college (and might justifiably do so), if there is a conflict between sending her child to college and fulfilling her moral duties, there is no question of what she ought to do: no matter what her circumstances, and no matter what her preference structure, she ought to fulfill her moral duties. If the only way to provide for her child's college education is for her to sell narcotics or embezzle money from her employer or rob a bank, tough luck for college. She ought not to do those things, even if she very much wants to and, furthermore, would have to in order to achieve her other goals. The fact (if it is a fact) that Sally values bank-robbing (say) and has to engage in it in order to achieve her ends goes no distance whatsoever toward justifying her actions. We all recognize that morality

makes demands on us that cannot be trumped by considerations of personal gain, pleasure, or happiness. If the choice is between one of these and the demands of morality, then moral demands prevail.

The above discussion was aimed at helping us appreciate the force of the second of the two central questions for which we will seek answers below. That second question was: why should we care about morality? None of this discussion goes any way towards answering this question. But perhaps now we can see more clearly what it is asking. When we consider the way in which we take morality and its demands to work, one thing that is evident is that it seems to have this categorical and intrinsically overridding grip on us. What could explain this fact?

The grounds of objective morality

The first of our two questions is: what explains the truth of moral claims? Before we move to consider answers to this question, it important to note that objective moral claims come in more than one variety. Because of this we might expect that there will be more than one type of ground for moral claims. For example, moral philosophers commonly insist on a distinction between claims concerning *the good* and claims concerning *the right*. Claims of the first sort tell us what sorts of things are worth pursuing: it is good to learn a foreign language, tell the truth, and give your life to helping the poor. But notice that these three examples of good things fall into three very different categories. The first – learning a language – while good, still falls short of counting as a *moral* good. The third – giving your life to serve the poor – counts as a moral good. But doing such a thing requires a sacrifice that most of us think goes way above and beyond the call of duty. We might say that it rises to the level of a moral good, but goes well *beyond* what you are obligated to do. Philosophers call actions of this sort *supererogatory* acts.

The second example, however, truth telling, seems to be both a moral good *and* an obligation. Goods that fall into this category make up what philosophers call "the right." Things that are *right* are moral goods that have a special hold on you, because you are *obligated* to pursue them.

In what follows we will consider four arguments that God is in some way required to ground the truth of objective morality. Some of these arguments apply specifically to the good, while others apply to the right.

Laws imply a law-giver

Many theists are fond of an argument, frequently cast in the form of a slogan, declaring that since all laws require law-givers, *moral* laws require a *moral* law-giver. Surely, the argument continues, moral law-givers are intentional, deliberate agents. Thus, some intentional, deliberate moral agent exists, and is the ground of objective moral truths.

The problem with the argument, of course, is that the underlying premise (or slogan) is false or question-begging. There are all sorts of law-like or normative principles that seemingly have no need of a law-giver to explain their truth: laws of nature and laws of mathematics, for example. It is hard to see why the Commutative Law or the Laws of Thermodynamics require a law-giver.

Furthermore, even if the theist can show that contingent laws, like the laws of nature, do require a law-giver, it is hard to see how the same case might be made when it comes to mathematical laws. Unlike natural laws, mathematical laws are necessary truths – truths that could not be otherwise no matter what. If that is right, then these laws seem to be true in a way that is not dependent on anything else, including the acts of any law-giver. Since moral truths seem also to be necessary truths, we have reason to think that these truths do not depend on the acts of a law-giver either. As a result, the general claim that laws require a law-giver seems unsustainable.

Necessary truths require a necessary being

While it might be true that necessary truths wouldn't depend for their truth on the act of a law-giver, it may be too hasty to conclude that there can be no explanation at all for necessary truths. In fact a number of theists have argued that moral claims are necessary truths but that their truth is somehow explained by some sort of special, non-natural ground. Since the various parts of nature exist contingently and are arranged as they are contingently, those things cannot serve to ground necessary truths. Nor could necessary truths obviously be grounded in divine commands since at least some of these might also be contingent. But that doesn't mean that necessary truths can't be grounded in other kinds of special, supernatural facts. And so those who think that necessary

truths stand in need of some sort of ground or explanation will naturally insist that the grounds for necessary truths are precisely such special, supernatural facts.[3]

The seventeenth-century German philosopher Gottfried Leibniz defended the necessity of moral truths, arguing that they must thus have grounds of the same sort as other necessary truths, namely, necessary states of the divine intellect. In rejecting the extreme voluntarism of Samuel von Pufendorf, Leibniz writes:

> Neither the norms of conduct itself nor the essence of justice depends on [God's] free choice, but rather on eternal truths, or objects of the divine intellect . . . Justice follows certain rules of equality and proportion which are no less grounded in the immutable nature of things and in the divine ideas than are the principles of arithmetic and geometry.[4]

This argument rests on a number of assumptions, some more controversial than others. It is at least moderately controversial that necessary truths require non-natural grounds. It is a necessary truth that nothing can be both entirely red and entirely green at the same time. Yet it is hard to see how the truth of this claim depends in any way on some sort of non-natural ground.

More controversial is the claim that moral truths are necessary. But note that even if we grant these controversial claims, it is not at all clear that the grounds for necessary moral truths must be God or the divine nature or intellect. Many philosophers have accepted the claim that necessary truths require exotic, non-natural entities as grounds, but not all of them have thought that they must be grounded in or explained by the activity or character of a divine being. Plato and his followers, for example, hypothesized the existence of non-natural entities or "forms" which play the grounding role. Why, then, must we conclude that the grounds for necessary moral truths are some divine reality as opposed to these more austere, Platonic forms? This argument offers no answer to this question.

[3] Contemporary defenses of this view have been offered by Richard Swinburne, *The Coherence of Theism* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1977), and C. Stephen Layman, *The Shape of the Good* (Notre Dame: University of Notre Dame Press, 1991).

[4] Gottfried Leibniz in *Opera Omnia*, Louis Dutens (ed.), Geneva, 1768, Volume IV, iii, p. 275.

Good requires a paradigmatic standard of goodness

Historically, a number of philosophers argued that any property which a thing could have to greater and lesser degrees must have a perfect exemplar. The best way to understand the underlying argument is by way of an example. Suppose a professor asks her class to take out a piece of paper and to draw a circle. Each student grabs a pen or pencil and draws something roughly round. After looking at each paper the professor says, "Those look good, but no one has drawn a shape that is perfectly circular; try again." So, they try again. Does anyone draw a perfect circle the next time? Probably not, though the shapes are probably getting closer to the ideal of perfect circularity. Close to the *what*? The ideal – perfect circularity. What exactly is this thing that everyone is trying to get their circle to resemble? It seems as if there must be *something* that they are trying to approximate when they draw their circles. After all, it would be odd if there were *nothing* that they were trying to approximate. How could one try to approximate nothing?

Reasoning of this sort inclines some philosophers to think that properties which can approximate an ideal to a greater or lesser extent require some really existing perfect instance of that ideal. St. Thomas Aquinas, for example, famously argued this way in one of his arguments for the existence of God:

> The fourth way [to argue for God's existence] is taken from the gradation to be found in things. Among beings there are some more and some less good, true, noble and the like. But "more" and "less" are predicated of different things, according as they resemble in their different ways something which is the maximum, as a thing is said to be hotter according as it more nearly resembles that which is hottest; so that there is something which is truest, something best, something noblest and, consequently, something which is uttermost being; for those things that are greatest in truth are greatest in being . . . Now the maximum in any genus is the cause of all in that genus; as fire, which is the maximum heat, is the cause of all hot things. Therefore there must also be something which is to all beings the cause of their being, goodness, and every other perfection; and this we call God.[5]

[5] *Summa Theologica*, Fathers of the English Dominican Province (trans.), Christian Classics, 1981, I Question 2, article 3, response.

The premises of this argument have proven notoriously difficult to defend, relying on a number of underlying claims which are widely rejected. This includes the central claim of the argument: when we encounter cases of properties that admit of greater and lesser degrees there must be some really existing perfect instance of that property. In fact, Aquinas' own example in the passage seems to reveal the problem quite strikingly. He argues that since things are more or less hot, there must be something that is maximally hot. But, of course, there is no such maximally hot thing (no matter what your friends say about their favorite Hollywood star).

It is also worth noticing that even if we accept the premises of Aquinas' argument, at best we can conclude that there is "something which is the maximum" with respect to goodness. What would this "something" be and what would it be like? It *could* be that it is a personal being which exemplifies goodness perfectly, and in that case, the "something" would at least have one of the central properties that theists attribute to God. But why think that perfect goodness would have to be *personal*?

Robert Adams has recently attempted to answer this question. According to Adams, excellence and moral excellence are best thought of as resemblance relations (like the relation between the students' circles and "perfect circularity") between things and Maximal Goodness.[6] What sort of thing would Maximal Goodness be? Adams argues that it would have to be personal:

> Theists have sometimes tried to infer the personality of the supreme Good from the premise that persons, as such, are the most excellent things that we know, from which it is claimed to follow that the supremely excellent being must be of that sort. A more cautious line of argument begins with the premise, harder to deny, that most of the excellences that are most important to us, and of whose value we are most confident, are excellences of persons or of qualities or actions or works or lives or stories of persons. So if excellence consists in resembling or imaging a being that is the Good itself, nothing is more important to the role of the Good itself than that persons and

[6] Robert Adams, *Finite and Infinite Goods* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1999). This component of the view is primarily defended in the first section of the book, pages 13–130. As one might expect, since resemblance is such a slippery affair Adams needs to, and does, provide a more refined view. In particular, he holds that moral excellence is a species of value excellence generally where the latter is to be understood as "resembling God in a way that could serve God as a reason for loving the thing" (p. 36).

> their properties should be able to resemble or image it. That is obviously likelier to be possible if the Good itself is a person or importantly like a person.[7]

Adams' argument depends on two controversial claims that we can only mention here. The first is the claim that excellence is to be thought of as a relation. The second is that moral excellence is best understood as a relation to a Maximally Excellent Person. As we noted earlier, followers of Plato, to pick one example, have been content to understand excellence as a relation between things and "forms." Does the Maximally Excellent thing need to be personal in order to play this relational role? Perhaps.

Moral obligation requires (personal) imperatives

Our first three arguments aim to show that the truth of claims about what is good can be explained only by the existence or activity of a divine being. Our fourth argument focuses specifically on the way in which God might be necessary for grounding claims about what is *right*.

Some philosophers argue that claims about the right must be grounded in something over and above whatever grounds claims about the good. Something, they argue, must serve to distinguish when goods rise to the level of the moral and when they go so far as to become supererogatory. Not all philosophers agree that there must be an extra fact which explains why some actions are both good *and* obligatory. For example, someone might deny that there are any supererogatory acts because they think we have an obligation to perform *every* good action. Surely these obligations would be merely *prima facie* (literally "at first glance") obligations. Since there are so many good things that you could do at any one time you would, at any given time, have numerous and conflicting obligations. Your *ultima facie* or "all things considered" obligation would then be to do that which is best among those competing obligations. So if it is best that you give all of your time, money, and energy to serving the needs of the poor, you would, on this view, be obliged to do that.

For those who think that some additional grounds are needed, is there any reason to think that divine command is an especially good ground? Robert Adams argues that it is. He writes:

[7] *Ibid.*, p. 42.

> The most important distinction between the right, or obligation, and the good, in my opinion, is that right and wrong, as matters of obligation, must be understood in relation to *social* contexts, broadly understood, but that is not true of all the types of good with which we are concerned. The beauty of a scene or the badness of a pain can be understood in abstraction from any social setting . . . If I have an obligation on the other hand, I believe it can only be in a personal relationship or in a social system of relationships.[8]

Adams points to two facts about obligation that he thinks weigh strongly in favor of his view. First, obligatory actions are actions that we *care* about performing. That is, if someone agreed that a certain action was indeed obligatory but then shrugged it off by saying "But I don't care about that," we would suppose that they did not really understand what it means to be obligated to do something. This feature of morality was discussed earlier, when we noted that the demands of morality apply universally, whether we want them to or not.

What is it about obligatory acts that could explain this intrinsic motivational feature? Adams argues that the most plausible answer is that obligations are imposed on us only by way of the demands of a *system of social relationships*. According to this "social theory of obligation" an obligation to perform an action consists of "being required . . . by another person or a group of persons to do it." How does this explain the motivational force of obligations? The answer is that the motivational force arises because we value the social relationships we find ourselves in. Complying with an obligation is thus "an expression of my valuing and respecting the relationship."[9]

Second, there are close and important connections between the notions of obligation and guilt. When you fail to perform an action that you are obliged to perform, you are guilty; and guilt carries with it two important connotations. First, we usually tie our use of the word "guilt" to wrong actions that did or might have harmed *some person*. Second, we usually associate guilt with *being alienated* from other people. For this reason we often seek forgiveness from others when we commit a wrong as a way of being "freed" from guilt.

Both of these features argue strongly in favor of the notion that obligation involves demands imposed in a social context. The obvious question to

[8] *Ibid*., p. 233. [9] *Ibid*., p. 242.

ask at this point is: why think that the social context involves God? Won't purely human social contexts suffice to establish moral obligations? For Adams, the answer is no, and for reasons we have already considered. If obligation is reduced to demands made by actual human communities, then obligation would lose its *objective* character. The obligation not to commit genocide cannot be undone simply because a human social community changes its demands. However, if obligation arises through the social demands imposed on us by God's commands, this strong notion of the objectivity of moral obligation can be preserved.[10]

Moral motivation and religion

The second central question about the nature of objective morality was this: why should we care about being moral? Unlike the theoretical question of how to *ground the truth* of moral claims, this question concerns the distinctly practical matter of motivation.

There are, of course, many different answers to the question of why we ought to care about morality. Plato, for example, presses for the view that to be a virtuous person – to be, in other words, the sort of person who habitually behaves morally – is to be a psychologically healthy person. Immoral behavior promotes vice and therefore causes disease in the soul. Thus, we should care about behaving morally for exactly the same reason we care about (say) exercising or eating a healthy diet: it promotes our health and makes us better off. In a similar vein, the three main theistic religions are often interpreted as recommending that we care about morality as a means of achieving some sort of reward or avoiding some sort of punishment in the afterlife. And, of course, there are many others.

Our goal in this section, however, is not to canvass the variety of answers that have been offered in the historical and contemporary literature to the question of why we should care about morality. Rather, given that our topic is *religion* and ethics, we want to focus our attention on an argument for the conclusion that belief in God *makes a difference* in whether we care about morality. As we shall see, if this argument is sound, then theists have greater reason to care about moral behavior than non-theists have.

[10] *Ibid.*, p. 248.

The argument we shall consider is a reconstructed version of an argument offered by Immanuel Kant. According to Kant, the possibility of living the moral life would be diminished or extinguished unless we were to accept belief in theism.[11] Robert Adams reconstructs his argument as follows:

8.1. It would be demoralizing not to believe that there is a moral order of the universe.
8.2. Demoralization is morally undesirable.
8.3. Therefore, there is a moral advantage in believing that there is a moral order of the universe.
8.4. Theism provides the most adequate theory of a moral order of the universe.
8.5. Therefore, there is a moral advantage to accepting theism.[12]

Adams tells us that, by "demoralization," he means "a weakening or deterioration of moral motivation."[13] Likewise, to say that something provides a "moral advantage" is to say that it provides us with motives – additional motives that we otherwise would not have – that encourage or help to sustain moral behavior. Thus, the conclusion amounts to the claim that theists have greater moral motivation – and so greater reason to care about moral behavior – than non-theists.

Note, however, that the first premise can be understood in at least two different ways, depending on how one understands the term "moral order." On the first, "universalistic" reading, to say that the world has a moral order is to say that the world is set up so that "morally good actions will probably contribute to a good world-history."[14] On the second "individualistic" reading, to say that the universe has a moral order is to say that our universe is set up so that those who act virtuously ultimately become happy. Thus, we arrive at the following two understandings of 8.1:

8.1.* It would be demoralizing not to believe that morally good actions will probably contribute to a good world history.

[11] Such arguments seem to be at work in Kant's *Religion Within the Bounds of Reason Alone*.
[12] Robert M. Adams, "Moral Arguments for Theistic Belief," in *The Virtue of Faith* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1987), p. 151.
[13] *Ibid*., p. 151. [14] *Ibid*., p. 151.

8.1.** It would be demoralizing not to believe that morally good actions will lead to one's own ultimate happiness.

Suppose we read 8.1 as 8.1*. The argument then suggests that if you believe that your performing a good action ultimately contributes to the overall goodness of the universe, then good action takes on a greater measure of importance for you. Likewise, if you believe that things will ultimately turn out badly no matter what you do, or that the long term effects of your action are just as likely to lead to bad ends as good ones, you will likely feel discouraged or ambivalent about doing the right thing.

However, read in this way the argument seems vulnerable to at least two objections. First, 8.1* seems rather dubious: it is not clear that it really makes much practical difference to an individual that his action will contribute towards an overall good world history. Of course, we might well care in the abstract about contributing to a good world history. But the point here is that it is hard to imagine being demoralized simply by the thought that particular moral acts of ours make little or no difference to the global good. Second, the argument neglects the fact that the universe might exhibit a moral order (in the sense given by 8.1*) even if there were no theistic deity. Consider, for example, the view held by many sects of Buddhism and Hinduism that global moral order is maintained by means of karma. Those who are virtuous in this lifetime, but who still fall short of the ideal of enlightenment, are reincarnated in the next life in a better condition while those who are vicious are reincarnated in an inferior condition. This "karmic management system" seems to play the same role as God does in Kant's picture. So, while we might be able to conclude from Kant's argument that proper moral motivation requires belief in some sort of entity or process which ensures universal moral order, perhaps a non-theistic being or even purely impersonal process would suffice equally well.

Suppose, on the other hand, we replace 8.1 with 8.1**. This version of the argument initially appears more promising, since it plays on the more powerful motive of our own self-interest. But there is something strange about the argument under this reading as well. The argument encourages us to think this way: "Unless I think that acting morally will ultimately be good for me, I won't act morally. So, I should start to believe that acting morally will indeed ultimately be good for me." Is it sensible to reason in this way? Consider how such reasoning works in the abstract: "Unless I think that

doing X is good for me, I won't do X. So, I better start believing that X is good for me." Such reasoning makes sense if we *already have* good reason to do X, but not otherwise. (To see this, substitute in for X "hitting myself in the head with a brick" and note that the reasoning is just silly.) But if I *already have* good reason to think that X (acting morally, in the case of our argument) is good for me, then this argument is superfluous.

Adams suggest a further motivational argument which he sketches as follows:

> It is widely thought that moral judgments have an action- and preference-guiding force that they could not have unless everyone had reason to follow them in his [or her] actions and preferences. But there has also been widespread dissatisfaction with arguments purporting to show that everyone does have reason always to be moral . . . It is plausibly assumed, however, that virtually everyone has a deep and strong desire for his own happiness. So if happiness will in the long run be strictly proportioned to moral goodness, that explains how virtually everyone does have an important reason to want to be good.[15]

Thus, since this commonly held feature of morality is more likely to be true if theism is true than not, this feature of morality provides a reason to believe in theism.

This argument has a few controversial premises. But more importantly for our purposes, it seems to fall prey to the objection that afflicts other arguments above, namely, that while this feature of morality might require appeal to something beyond those things we find in ordinary nature, it does not necessarily require an appeal to theism. So, for example, it appears that once again an appeal to a system of "karmic management" (whether actually religiously grounded or not) will fit the bill just as well as theism.[16]

[15] *Ibid*., p. 158.

[16] We should note, however, that some have argued that belief in karma actually *undermines* moral motivation. Moreover, it has also been argued that the idea of a karmic management system is utterly implausible apart from the supposition that there is some organizing mind in charge of the administration of karmic rewards and punishments. So, in the end, appeals to karmic management might not do as well as theism in solving the problem of moral motivation (they might simply make it worse); or, on the other hand, they might be untenable apart from theistic belief. See, in this vein, Paul Edwards, *Reincarnation: A Critical Examination* (Amherst, NY: Prometheus Books, 2001), and Robin Collins, "Eastern Religions," in Michael Murray (ed.), *Reason for the Hope Within* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans Press, 1999).

Divine command theories of the right and the good

In Plato's famous dialogue *Euthyphro*, Socrates engages Euthyphro in a discussion of his plan to prosecute his own father for an unintentional killing. Socrates is puzzled by Euthyphro's confidence in his moral condemnation of his father in light of the moral ambiguities of the case. Perhaps in order to shake Euthyphro's confidence, Socrates poses a challenge to the view of moral uprightness or "piety" that Euthyphro endorses. On Euthyphro's view, piety is "that which is loved by the gods."

Socrates then asks the question: is the pious loved by the gods because it is pious, or is something pious because it is loved by the gods? Contemporary philosophers call Socrates' question and the dilemma that it spawns "The Euthyphro Dilemma." The Euthyphro Dilemma is of interest to us because, as we have seen, many philosophers think, like Euthyphro, that important ethical claims depend on facts about God in some essential way. If that is right, these philosophers will also need to give us a response to the Dilemma.

Consider the Euthyphro Dilemma as it arises in a theistic context with respect to morally good actions. Thus: are morally good acts good because they are loved by God, or does God love them because they are good? As with any dilemma, this one presents us with two alternatives, each of which seems to have fatal consequences.

Suppose we accept the second horn of the dilemma. On this view, something counts as good simply in virtue of its being loved by God. But this view faces three very serious problems. We can call them the *contingency problem*, the *non-objectivity problem*, and the *anything goes problem*. First, the claim that good actions are good because the gods love them seems to make truths about goodness objectionably contingent. If nothing prevents God from loving things that are different from what God actually loves, then goodness can change from world to world or time to time. This is obviously objectionable to those who believe that claims about morality are, if true, necessarily true.

Second, it casts doubt on the notion that morality is genuinely objective. If moral claims can sensibly be regarded as expressions of divine tastes or preferences, why not similarly regard them as sometimes expressing our tastes or preferences as well? What is it about God that *privileges* his tastes, so that what he loves or hates becomes good or bad *for everyone*? It is, one might

think, rather difficult to see any reason for privileging divine tastes over creaturely tastes; and so if we think that morality depends in part on what the gods love, it seems we should also think that it depends in part on what we love too – in which case it seems to be merely subjective.

Third, and most worrisome, however, is the fact that on this view (as applied to *the good*) we are forced to admit that if God were to love something that we now regard as morally reprehensible – torturing innocents, for example – then such an action *would become good*. Since the love of God determines the standards of goodness, his loving such torture is all it takes to make that action good. And this seems wrong. We are inclined to think that no matter what God thinks about torturing innocents, such an action is paradigmatically wrong. In fact, when we engage in moral theorizing, we typically think that when a moral theory entails consequences like this, such entailments are fatal for the theory.

On the other hand, the second horn of the Dilemma is similarly problematic. If God loves good actions because they are good, rather than the other way around, then it seems that God's sovereignty and independence are threatened. There is something – the standards of moral goodness – over which God is *not* sovereign. God is bound by the laws of morality instead of being their establisher. Moreover, God *depends* for his goodness on the extent to which he conforms to an independent moral standard. Thus, God is not absolutely independent.

What shall we say about this dilemma? Suppose we embrace the first horn of the dilemma. *Theological voluntarism* is the view that good and evil are entirely dependent on what God wills and nothing else. Medieval philosopher Jean de Gerson put the view straightforwardly as follows:

> Nothing is evil except because prohibited [by God]; and nothing is good except because accepted by God; and God does not therefore will and approve our actions because they are good, but they are therefore good because he approves them. Similarly, they are therefore evil because he prohibits and disapproves of them.[17]

Similar remarks can be found in the works of the Roman Catholic philosopher Peter d'Ailly and Protestant theologian Martin Luther.

[17] Jean de Gerson, *On the Spiritual Life of the Soul*, Reading I, Corollary X, cited in William Wainwright, *Religion and Morality* (Burlington, VT: Ashgate Publishing, 2005), p. 74.

Thus baldly stated, it is hard to see how one might avoid the three pitfalls that we identified earlier. But there are ways of supplementing one's voluntarism that seem to provide the resources for doing so. For example, one might insist that God's preferences are freely formed, but also necessary. Thus, in chapter 1 we considered the suggestion that God's freedom might be compatible with his inability to sin. If that is right, then God's freedom might also be compatible with his being unable to *command* anything other than what he has commanded. (One might even think that the two inabilities are connected: God cannot sin for the same reason he cannot command differently – namely, it is part of his very nature to love kindness, abhor cruelty, and so on.) If this is right, then one has a voluntarist position (facts about moral goodness might depend on divine commands) but one can easily avoid both the contingency objection and the anything-goes objection. The concern about objectivity remains; but here one might respond by saying that divine tastes and preferences are relevantly different from human tastes and preferences. The latter do not provide objectivity, one might say, precisely because (unlike God's) they are neither necessary nor objectively authoritative.

Alternatively, we might try to embrace the second horn of the Dilemma. In the preceding sections of this chapter we already have considered views which give God a central role in morality and which implicitly contain ways of resolving the Dilemma. For example, Robert Adams' theory of goodness holds that goodness does not depend on what God loves or wills even though goodness is centrally connected to the being of God. On that view, goodness of a thing (or action or state of character) depends on the ways in which that thing *resembles* God. This, then, seems to be a way of maintaining that God *loves* good things because they are good without committing oneself to the claim that facts about goodness or moral standards or the like are *independent* of God. Moreover, the threat to God's sovereignty is mitigated because nobody feels a burden to say that God is sovereign over his very nature.

Note, however, that, though this view might well explain what makes morally good acts *good*, it does not obviously have the resources to explain what makes them *obligatory*. And so the Euthyphro question arises once again: are morally good acts *obligatory* because they are commanded by God? Or are they commanded by God because they are obligatory? The former suggestion seems to fall prey to the same problems that plague the first

horn of the original Dilemma. On the other hand, the latter question simply raises the question of *why* morally good acts are obligatory. After all, not *all* good things are obligatory. It might be good to give all your money to the poor. It is not obviously obligatory that you do so. Thus, some story would have to be told about what makes (certain) morally good acts obligatory; and, moreover, the story would have to avoid the pitfalls associated with the second horn of the original Dilemma.

One might try to solve this problem by telling a story about moral obligation that parallels the story about moral goodness – grounding it somehow in God's essential nature. Doing so would allow one to avoid the problems associated with the second horn of the original Dilemma (threats to sovereignty and independence); but it is very hard to see *how* this could be done. Notably, Adams himself embraces voluntarism at this point.

Recall that earlier in this chapter we said that Adams thinks that moral obligation (unlike moral goodness) *is* dependent on divine commands. Pursuing certain goods and avoiding certain evils becomes obligatory for us only in so far as those things are commanded by God. However, because the commands are issued by a *loving* God, there are certain things that even God could not command. For example, because torturing innocents is intrinsically bad, God could never command us to do it, and even were God to do so, the command could not obligate us since we can never be obligated to do something that is intrinsically evil.

The trouble with this view, however, unlike the voluntarist position described earlier in this section, is that it avoids the contingency problem and the anything-goes problem apparently by saying that some obligations depend on divine commands whereas others do not. For it looks as if we will be obligated to refrain from torture *regardless* of what God commands, simply because torture is inherently bad. But if that is right, then it is hard to see why God's commands should be relevant to any other (universal) obligation either.[18]

[18] Obviously God's commands will be relevant to *some* obligations. For example, the Hebrew Bible tells us that God commanded Jonah to prophesy to the Ninevites. Presumably *that* obligation is wholly dependent on God's command. But it is not a universal obligation. (The rest of us don't have to go find Ninevites and prophesy to them.)

Religion and public discourse

It will come as no surprise to any reader that conflicts over the relationship between religion and politics are widespread and serious. Whether it is American judges trying to determine the appropriate relation of church and state, theocrats in Iran aiming to establish an "authentically Islamic state," or factions in Northern Ireland or Southern Lebanon struggling to determine the rights and roles of religious minorities and majorities, the confusion concerning the role of religion in matters of the state is important in a way that is hard to overestimate.

Of course, philosophical theorizing about the relationships between religion and politics is not a new phenomenon. In early modern Europe religiously inspired wars flared repeatedly in ways that threatened to destabilize the entire continent. These persistent conflicts increased the sense of urgency among philosophers and political theorists who sought defensible philosophical grounds for establishing stability and peace. Then and now, two issues are of paramount importance. The first concerns the question of whether it is good for the citizens of a state to tolerate those who hold religious beliefs and engage in religious practices that conflict with their own. Throughout modern history states have engaged in a variety of intolerant practices aimed at forcibly converting, killing, or exiling those who dissent from the majority (or otherwise officially sanctioned) state religion. Many in early modern Europe sought to stem such practices by arguing that sound moral and political reasoning demands religious toleration. The second issue concerns the role that religious views or concerns should be allowed to play in the governance decisions in liberal democracies. In this section of the chapter we will examine both of these issues.

Religious toleration

To most in the West, the claims that the state is to be tolerant of religion and religious diversity, and that religious sects and religious individuals are to behave with tolerance towards one another, border on truisms. But such ideas are not and have not been universally shared. On what grounds then can a stance of religious toleration be defended? There are two general types of arguments for toleration, one pragmatic and the other epistemological.

The seventeenth-century British philosopher John Locke argued that states are required to tolerate religion and religious diversity because the interests of the state extend only to "procuring, preserving, and advancing" the "civil interests" of citizens. Religious organizations, on the other hand, are voluntary associations in which people engage in "the public worshipping of God, in such a manner as they judge acceptable to him, and effectual to the salvation of their souls."[19] Thus for Locke, the state is obliged to be tolerant of all forms of "public worshipping" as long as it does not interfere with the civil interests of any citizens of the state.

Locke's view does not give religious organizations unfettered freedom. For example, a religious organization would not be permitted to engage in activities like human sacrifice or illegal drug use, even for religious purposes. In addition, the state might block religious individuals from engaging in actions that harm their own civil interests. The state might, for example, use coercive means to force someone to accept a life-saving blood transfusion even if his or her religious community regards that form of treatment as religiously objectionable. Still, this leaves religious individuals and communities with a great deal of latitude in their religious activities.

While Locke's position has some initial appeal, critics have noted that it is not likely to persuade people who are not already in favor of state-sanctioned tolerance. Many (Islamic theocracies, for example) hold that it is just wrong to think that the role of the state is limited to advancing "civil interests." They will argue rather that states are constituted to procure, preserve, and advance the interests of the whole person, including distinctively religious interests such as obedience to God's commands or the salvation of the citizen's eternal souls. Locke's position lacks resources to convince such critics.

In the same work Locke offers another pragmatic argument that state tolerance of religious diversity is essential since the only alternative would be (a) to purge religion from the state or (b) to enforce religious conformity. However, doing either of these things would require that the state exercise its coercive powers to change citizen's religious commitment – commitment which, in Locke's words are "inward persuasions of the mind." But, Locke continues, coercive force is simply unable to change minds. Beliefs are not

[19] John Locke, *A Letter Concerning Toleration*, in G. and J. Rivington (eds.), *The Works of John Locke* (Oxford, 1824), Volume 5, pp. 10–13.

under our voluntary control and so threats and violence cannot do anything to bring about this result.[20] States must thus adopt a posture of toleration towards diverse religions.

While Locke is right that we do not have direct voluntary control over our beliefs, this does not entail that coercive force cannot change minds in other ways. Pascal, for example, argued that if we do not believe that Christianity is true, but nevertheless think that there are good practical reasons to accept it, the prudent thing to do is to adopt various Christian practices – church attendance, Bible reading, and so on – with the intention of generating such belief. If these indirect mechanisms sometimes succeed, this might be enough reason for the state to take it upon itself to coerce citizens to engage in religious practices and rituals in order to bring about the change of belief that Locke thinks is impossible. In light of this, Locke's second pragmatic argument in favor of tolerance also seems to fail.

In addition to these pragmatic arguments, philosophers have offered a number of epistemic arguments in favor of tolerance. These arguments share in common the idea that accepting or acting on intolerant policies will always involve relying on beliefs that are *uncertain* in some way or other, because they are doubtful on their own, or at least *more* doubtful than beliefs that support policies of tolerance. The seventeenth-century French philosopher Pierre Bayle, for example, argued that any principle that comes from revelation and which conflicts with the "clear and distinct notions of natural light" must be rejected as false. Bayle thinks that religiously intolerant policies all run afoul of this test and thus that any religious believer who holds such a policy is rationally obligated to give it up.

Advocates of intolerant policies will not likely be persuaded by such arguments. Bayle's argument depends on the claim that state sponsored coercion of belief is obviously immoral. But those who commend intolerant policies might well respond that their coercive tactics are not immoral after all since they are aiming to protect people from serious evils such as eternal damnation. It is not clear that this impasse can be resolved.

Immanuel Kant offered a quite different epistemic argument for tolerance. Kant held that full moral conscientiousness requires that we only act on moral principles that we are certain are true. However, those who practice extremely intolerant policies are surely acting on policies of which they

[20] *Ibid.*, p. 11.

cannot be certain. Kant considers an especially extreme case in which a heretic is condemned to death for his beliefs. In this case, he contends:

> That it is wrong to deprive a man of his life because of his religious faith is certain, unless . . . a Divine Will, made known in extraordinary fashion, has ordered it otherwise. But that God has ever uttered this terrible injunction can be asserted only on the basis of historical documents and it is never [absolutely] certain. After all, the revelation has reached the [executioner] only through men and has been interpreted by men . . . it is at least possible that in this instance a mistake has prevailed.[21]

Kant's argument hinges on the claims that we must act only on moral principles which we hold with certainty, and that God could never reveal to us any moral principle that could rise to that level. Even if the second claim is true, however, it is hard to see why one would accept this very strong first claim. It might be that it is wrong for you to act from moral principles which you have not thought about at all, or in which you have little confidence. But a requirement of certainty seems too strong.

Perhaps a weaker version of Kant's argument would suffice according to which, when we come across a purported revealed divine command that seems to contradict a moral principle that appears certain to us, it is immoral for us to act on that command. So, when you take a Biblical passage to recommend that you use coercive force to gain converts – something which otherwise seems quite wrong – you should refrain from acting on it (at least in part because the justification for your belief about the command would seem to be outweighed by the certainty you have concerning the moral principle).

Unfortunately, critics of tolerance will not likely be convinced by this argument either. First, even if Kant is completely correct, there are all sorts of intolerant policies that would not violate moral principles that seem otherwise obvious. While murdering heretics might be obviously objectionable, excluding dissenters from one's community, or certain privileges in the community, is not. Furthermore, critics are likely to think that biblical texts and their interpretations have a very high degree of warrant for us. When they do, they will be able to outweigh even moral principles in which one has a good measure of confidence.

[21] Immanuel Kant, *Reason Within the Limits of Reason Alone* (New York: Harper and Row, 1960), p. 175.

The role of religious belief in liberal democracies

While on the one hand defenders of liberal democracy have argued for policies that are tolerant towards religion and religious diversity among their citizens, a number of recent liberal theorists have argued, on the other hand, that the role of religion in civil matters must be severely constrained. Democracies are founded on the notion that citizens of the state can engage in collective decision making, and that this decision making imposes obligations on all citizens that can be backed by coercive enforcement measures. Still, we all recognize that this decision-making power by the majority is not entirely unconstrained. The majority, for example, does not have the authority to enact policies which violate the fundamental rights of citizens. Even if, for example, the majority wants to use all blue-eyed citizens as slaves or as unwilling subjects in medical experiments, they lack the authority to make and enforce such policies.

Are there any other limits on the authority of the democratic majority aside from these fundamental rights of individual citizens? Some think so. For example, imagine that the majority decides that every car manufactured and sold in the state must be black. When polled, all of the citizens who voted for the new policy explain their decision by saying that they voted for it just because they like black cars. Are these permissible grounds on which to make policies that govern everyone, even those with different preferences? It hardly seems so. After all, why should the simple preferences of the majority come to have legal force over you, someone who really dislikes black cars? While not a very serious matter, something about this governance arrangement seems unjust.

Cases like this have led some political theorists to argue that when citizens are acting in their role as policy decision makers, they are obligated to make those decisions only on certain sorts of grounds. John Rawls argues that, at least when it comes to the most central aspects of state policy, what Rawls calls "questions of constitutional essentials and questions of basic justice," citizens are obliged to make decisions "in terms each could reasonably expect others might endorse as consistent with their freedom and equality."[22] More specifically, Rawls claims that in justifying our decision making "we are to appeal only to presently accepted general beliefs and

[22] John Rawls, *Political Liberalism* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1993), p. 218.

forms of reasoning found in common sense, and the methods and conclusions of science when these are not controversial."[23]

The reason for these constraints is apparent. If citizens are allowed to make decisions on the basis of reasons that each *could not in principle* reasonably expect others might endorse, then the results of these decisions might be unjustly coercive in the way the policy about black cars would be. Decision making in liberal democracies must take place by appeals to such "public reasons" in order to provide a shared public basis for political justification and authority.

Such restrictions, however, have a straightforward and important consequence: since religious beliefs are justified by *private* reasons (appeals to religious experience, religious authorities, or "faith") those beliefs would not be permitted to play a role when citizens are engaged in making decisions, at least when it comes to the central issues Rawls identifies. However, this constraint extends beyond religious belief. Rawls argues that citizens are not permitted to invoke any "comprehensive doctrine" when engaged in civil decision making about constitutional essentials and matters of basic justice. As a result, one can no more appeal to one's Marxist views than one can appeal to one's Mormon views. Citizens with religious (or Marxist, or . . .) convictions are, of course, welcome to defend policies that are motivated by their religious commitments, but only when those policies can *also* be supported by sufficient public reasons. In fact, in some of his most recent work on the topic, Rawls even allows that religious citizens could argue for civil policies on the basis of private reasons as long as sufficient public reasons are offered in support of the appropriate policy "in due course."[24]

What should we think of these restrictive positions? Rawls emphasizes the importance of theoretical agreement for just and stable societies while minimizing the role of disagreement and compromise to the point where the Rawlsian ideal seems to become unrealistic. In real states there will be wide divergence of opinion when it comes to what counts as a "good reason" or a reason "each could reasonably expect others might endorse." Many religious believers might think that their religion is rationally supported and that their reasons are ones others might endorse. Others will

[23] *Ibid.*, p. 224.

[24] John Rawls, "The Idea of Public Reason Revisited," in *The University of Chicago Law Review* 64 (1997), p. 783.

disagree. How then can we settle, on the Rawlsian picture, which reasons are admissible? No easy answer suggests itself.

Paul Weithman argues that such difficulties render the Rawlsian ideal unworkable. As a result, he proposes that citizens are obligated to advocate for policies when they can offer reasons favoring the claim that the policies would be genuinely good for the state. However, because there will be widely differing conceptions of what counts as a good or accessible reason by various constituencies, we cannot expect or mandate that the reasons offered will be seen as good or accessible by everyone. This may, Weithman notes, make some citizens "resent being offered reasons they regard as inaccessible, but it would be a mistake to cite their resentment as evidence that those who offered them the inaccessible reasons have violated some moral obligation."[25] Thus, according to this view, citizens in liberal democracies do not violate their duties as citizens when they choose to engage in decision making on the basis of religious reasons that they can articulate and use to show how such a policy would, by their lights, be good for the state.

Conclusion

In this chapter we have looked at the connection between religion and two central normative areas of thought: morality and politics. In the domain of morality we have seen that appeals to God or other forms of religious reality might be useful in providing answers to two crucial questions in moral philosophy: What grounds the truth of moral claims? and Why be moral? While religion might help provide answers to these questions, it is worth pointing out that other moral systems might as well. One question we have not considered (at least in any detail) here is: Does theism provide resources for answering these questions that is superior to other, non-religious moral theories? This is an eminently worthwhile question, but one that goes beyond what we can address here.

We also have considered two important questions about the connections between religion and politics: Are there reasonable grounds for promoting a policy of religious toleration? and What role, if any, should religious commitments be allowed to play when citizens act as political agents?

[25] Weithman 2002, p. 135.

Interestingly (though perhaps this is not surprising from those who know what to expect from philosophers!) the seemingly obvious answers are not so easy to defend. The available arguments for toleration all seem to rest on principles that defenders of intolerance are unlikely to accept. In addition, the arguments that religious reasons should be excluded from the political domain, while widely endorsed by political theorists, either seem to exclude too much or too little.

Further reading

Adams, Robert, *Finite and Infinite Goods* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2002).

Audi, Robert, *Religious Commitment and Secular Reason* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2000).

Eberle, Christopher, *Religious Conviction in Liberal Politics* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2002).

Helm, Paul (ed.), *Divine Commands and Morality* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1981).

Murphy, Mark, *Divine Authority* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2003).

Quinn, Philip, *Divine Commands and Moral Requirements* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1978).

Rea, Michael, "Naturalism and Moral Realism," in Thomas Crisp *et al.* (eds.), *Knowledge and Reality: Essays in Honor of Alvin Plantinga* (Dordrecht: Kluwer, 2006).

Wainwright, William, *Religion and Morality* (Burlington, VT: Ashgate Publishing, 2005).

Weithman, Paul, *Religion and the Obligations of Citizenship* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2006).

Wolterstorff, Nicholas and Robert Audi, *Religion in the Public Square* (New York: Rowman and Littlefield, 1996).

Zagzebski, Linda, *Divine Motivation Theory* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2004).